# A retrospective where people tell you what they really think

A practical guide to one honest team conversation.

Based on an approach shared by Alex Okun. Includes a suggested run sheet, questions, facilitation prompts and follow-up tools.

## BEFORE YOU START

If you are not genuinely curious about what your team thinks, or are not prepared to hear views you disagree with, do not use this approach in this way. Learn to stay still.

**ORIGINAL APPROACH** **Alex Okun**
ADDITIONS Practical facilitation tools

01 / BEFORE THE MEETING

# Prepare the conversation

Look back at a project, or look ahead to a deadline, a new semester or a busy period. The question changes; the need to listen does not.

## Choose one critical question

Decide what you genuinely want to learn. Five broad questions often give you five shallow answers. Give one important question enough room.

## Check your own readiness

Ask yourself what might be hard to hear, whether you can avoid defending past decisions, and what you can realistically act on.

## Choose the right facilitator

If people may struggle to speak openly in front of their manager, a neutral facilitator could make the conversation easier.

## Set clear expectations

Share the purpose and the question ahead of time. Explain what you will do with the feedback. Do not promise a change you cannot make.

## Protect the room

Do not record or transcribe unless it is critical for accessibility. If notes are needed, explain what is captured and who can see it.

### INVITATION YOU CAN ADAPT

“I’d like to understand how you feel about [topic]. We’ll focus on [question]. I’m here to listen, including to views I may not agree with. I’ll come back to you about what I heard and what we can do.”

02 / CHOOSE THE QUESTION

# One question. Real answers.

Choose one main question from these suggested examples, then ask short follow-up questions only when they help you understand.

## LOOKING BACK

What made this piece of work harder than it needed to be?
If we started again tomorrow, what would you change?
What helped us do good work, and what should we protect?

## LOOKING AHEAD

What worries you most about the next few months?
What could stop us doing good work?
What do we need to sort out before the next phase?

## HOW THE TEAM IS DOING

What is getting in the way of your best work?
What are we not talking about that we should be?
What do you need from the team or its leaders?

These are suggested adaptations, not a script from Alex. Use the one that fits your purpose.

03 / FACILITATE

# A 60-minute run sheet

Suggested timings, not part of Alex’s original template. Adjust them to the team size, subject and level of trust. Do not cut off something important simply because the clock runs out.

**00–05** **OPEN**

Explain the purpose, question and what happens afterwards. Invite clarification.

**05–10** **THINK**

Give quiet time to reflect. Do not rush to fill the silence.

**10–35** **LISTEN**

Invite views, ask for examples and resist the urge to defend.

**35–50** **EXPLORE**

Notice common themes and different experiences. Do not rush to solutions.

**50–60** **REFLECT**

Check what you heard, what you missed and when you will follow up.

## KEEP THESE QUESTIONS NEARBY

Can you give me an example? What was the impact?
Have I understood you correctly? What have we missed?

04 / WHEN IT GETS DIFFICULT

# Stay still.
# Then follow up.

Your response can change what people feel safe to say. The scenarios and suggested phrases below are practical additions to the original approach.

### Someone criticises your decision

Avoid debating the facts or explaining why you were right before understanding their experience. Try: “Can you tell me more about what that meant for your work?” Then ask: “What would have helped?”

### Nobody speaks

Avoid assuming silence means agreement or answering your own question. Try: “Take another minute to think. You can start with an example.” Written input might help if you explain how it will be used.

### One person dominates

Avoid letting the loudest voice stand in for the whole team. Try: “I want to make room for people we have not heard from. Does anyone see this differently?” Do not force people to speak.

### Someone asks for an immediate fix

Avoid promises or rushing into a debate about solutions. Try: “I hear that this matters. I want to understand the full picture before we decide what to do. We will include it in our follow-up.”

### Someone raises a sensitive concern

Do not promise absolute confidentiality. Pause, acknowledge the concern and explain whether it requires a separate, safer process. A retrospective does not replace reporting or support channels.

05 / AFTER THE MEETING

# Close the loop.

People have taken the time to speak openly. Tell them what you heard, what you will change, what needs more work and what is outside your control.

## At the end of the session

Reflect the main themes in plain English and ask what you misunderstood or missed. Agree who will follow up and when the team will hear back.

## A follow-up record you can reuse

| WHAT WE HEARD | WHAT WE WILL DO | OWNER / UPDATE |
| --- | --- | --- |
| Handoffs slow our work. | Map the handoff and test one improvement. | Named person and a clear date. |

## After the session

Send a short summary of what was heard, what will happen and what cannot change. At the next update, report what actually happened, not just what was promised.

### CREDIT AND ATTRIBUTION

Alex Okun shared the core approach: curiosity, one critical question, looking back or ahead, listening without defending, and the guidance on recording. The timed agenda, example questions, suggested phrases and follow-up tools are added practical resources.

**Shared with Alex Okun’s approval.**